

Here's a crash course on recovering data from a crashed hard drive!

Jayesh Limaye

Fact of life: when hard drives crash, they usually do so without warning. What results is a headache and, more importantly, heartache. But the data is usually not wiped clean from the crashed hard drive; rather, the file allocation table—which contains filenames and points to data on the drive—is what usually gets damaged. It is therefore technically possible to recover data in such situations; you only need to know the tools of the trade. The tool we're talking about is PC Inspector File Recovery—a freeware that can be downloaded from www.pcinspector.de/file_recovery/UK/welcome.htm.

If you've lost data on a partition on a drive other than C, just install the program in Windows. If your entire hard drive has crashed and you're unable to boot, install the program on another computer and attach your hard drive as a secondary drive on that computer.

STEP 1 Launch The Program
Launch PC Inspector File Recovery, choose English as your language, and click on the green tick button. Choose what kind of data you wish to recover by clicking on one of the three buttons to the left. If you choose Lost Data, go



Launch PC inspector File Recovery

directly to Step 6; if you choose lost drive, go directly to Step 8. If it is deleted data that you wish to recover, click on the icon at the top left.

STEP 2 Select The Drive
The program will scan your hard drive for some time for available partitions, after which it will display them. You will most likely be able to select the drive from the Logical Drives tab. It may sometimes be listed twice; select the entry containing the drive's letter.



Select the drive form which to recover data

To verify the drive's content, click the Preview button. Click on the tick button to continue to the next step.

STEP 3 Sniffing Out Deleted Files
The selected drive will now be scanned; this may take a few minutes. A Deleted folder will be displayed (with the Recycle Bin icon). You need to go through this folder to locate the files you wish to recover. You might find that the original filename has not been preserved. You can opt to search for the file in the following way: choose Object > Find, enter the file type, and click on the green tick to search.

STEP 4 Recovering The File
A list of matching files will appear after the search process ends. If the file you're searching for does not appear, you can use the Size and Date Modified columns to help identify it (assuming you know these details). Click on the top of these columns to arrange them accordingly, to make it easier to locate the file. Select the possible candidates by keeping on clicking on them while keeping [Ctrl] pressed. Keeping [Ctrl] pressed, right-click on them and choose Save to. Choose a location.

STEP 5 Check And Rename
After they are restored, you should try to open the files to see if they are indeed the files you were looking for. After confirming this, you can rename them to what they were and copy them to the original location later. If the files are not the ones you were searching for, return to PC Inspector File Recovery and try to search for them again.

STEP 6 Find Your Lost Data
Sometimes data is lost due to a quick format or due to system or program

crash. In such cases, you should choose the Lost Data button (the middle button on the left) in the main screen of PC Inspector File Recovery. In this case, data is retrieved in a way similar to deleted files. Select the drive from the Logical Drives list and click on the tick button when the Select Cluster Range dialog appears. The process of identification of files to be retrieved begins; this will take some time.

STEP 7 Retrieve The Lost Data
You will see that PC Inspector File Recovery has found hundreds of "lost" files—many will be fragments. It will take quite a bit of your time to go through them all, but it is worthwhile because you have a chance of getting back precious files. Repeat steps 3 to 5 to find your file and check its integrity.

STEP 8 Find The Lost Drive
If your partition table has been damaged, you may no longer be able to view



Scanning for lost data

any drive from the affected hard drive in the Logical Drives list. You'll have to manually search for it. Click on the Physical drive tab from the Select Drive dialog, and select your hard drive—usually named fixed disk #1. Click on Find logical drives.

STEP 9 Search Within Clusters
You can choose to scan the entire drive for lost drives, or if you have some idea about where the partition was physically located on the disk, you can move the sliders to concentrate the search on that particular area. Now click on the tick button and wait for the search to complete, after which you can select the logical drive to recover your files and folders (as explained in the previous steps).■

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It Won't Work...

Q I recently got myself a Tata Indicom Walky phone with a cable to connect it to the PC. I configured everything as told, but cannot connect to the Internet. When I try to view the modem diagnostics, I get an error.

Rajnish Mathur

A Your PC is not able to communicate with the modem in your phone. Check in the Phone and Modem Options in the Control Panel to see if you've installed a generic 33.6 Kbps model rather than a 56 Kbps modem. Access the modem properties and enter the initialisation settings as AT+CRM=1. This is assuming you've created the dial-up connection and are dialling the number "#777". The username and password are to be entered as "internet". In the phone, using the menu, you can access the modem settings; select the modem speed as 115 Kbps. You should now be able to connect.

Game Over—For Now

Q I have an Intel 915GAV chipset motherboard. When I start playing *The Sims 2*, I get the error message "ialmrnt5 display driver has stopped working normally", and I have to reboot the computer.

Eklavya Ashar

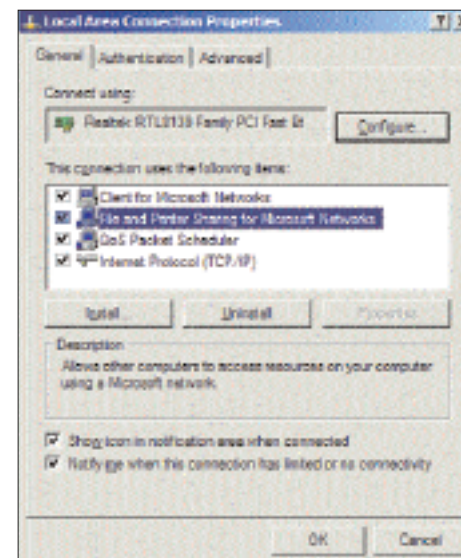
A This error is due to a bug in the Intel graphics driver. Install the latest drivers from downloadcenter.intel.com. If you still get the error, right-click on the *The Sims 2* icon, select Properties, and add the switch -w to the end of the target field so it looks something like "C:\Program Files\EA GAMES\The Sims 2\TSBin\Sims2.exe" -w. (The actual path may vary depending on where the game's been installed)

Direct Connect

Q I have a cable internet connection that requires me to dial using PPPoE. I recently installed a 4-port router and configured it to dial directly to my ISP. The problem is that it is not able to connect despite my having correctly configured the router to use PPPoE and entering the correct username and password.

M Krishnamurthy

A It looks like your ISP has locked your account to the MAC address of your network card, so you can only dial through that card. First, find the MAC address of your network card by typing `ipconfig /all` in a command prompt window. Copy that MAC address. Launch the administration page of your router and search for the option to set the WAN MAC address (sometimes referred to as "WAN MAC Address Cloning"). Enter the MAC address of your network card here and save the settings. This will set the MAC address of your router to the same as that of your network card, and it will seem to your ISP's server that the number is being dialled through your network card. You will then be able to connect to the Internet via the router.



Enable File and Printer sharing

Dead On Install!

Q I tried to install the Adobe GoLive! Tryout and Adobe Illustrator Tryout from one of your DVDs. They got installed, but when I try to run them, I get a message saying the products have expired, even though I've never installed them before.

Sabyasachi Sadhu

A Some software can work in the demo version mode only for a limited period of time (like three months) from the date of release. Usually, after this period, a newer trial or demo version of the software is released. Get it from www.adobe.com.

Wired—But Not Quite

Q I own a cyber-café with five computers running XP connected to an 8-port switch and one server. I am not able to access any of the five computers from any one of them. I can still ping them one from the another. What could the problem be?

Abhishek Gupta

A This often happens when File and Printer Sharing is disabled or if the Guest account is disabled. Open Network Connections, right-click on the network connection being used, and click Properties. Make sure the box next to File and Printer Sharing for Microsoft Networks is checked. Click OK.

You might be prompted to reboot the computer—do so. Open User Accounts in Control Panel and click Guests. In the next window, click on Turn On the Guest Account. This should solve the problem.

Cyber-Empty-Space

Q I can connect to the Internet but I can't open any Web sites on my Windows 98 SE PC.

Sunil Bihari

A Ping any site—ping `www.yahoo.com` in a command prompt—and if you get a reply, your browser is corrupt, and reinstalling it is the solution.

If you do not get a reply, run `winipcfg`. Click on the More Info button and verify that a DNS is specified. If the DNS is blank or 0.0.0.0, the computer is not being assigned a DNS address.

Close `winipcfg`. Disconnect from the Internet. Double-click on Network in the Control Panel, highlight TCP/IP > Dial-Up Adapter, and click Properties. Click on the DNS Configuration tab and verify that Disable DNS is selected.

If this was already selected, then contact your ISP to verify if any DNS settings need to be set up. ■